that location. During these discussions, both sides agreed to go back and restore the status quo ante. Just as the deliberations were winding down, the PLA side requested that since it was getting late and their main location quite far away, they be permitted to pitch two tents in the vicinity of the Junction as a temporary arrangement only. Our Commander said that he would consider this request and would have to consult his superiors on it. The two sides broke off just as dusk was setting in, and the IA delegation began the return walk. The PLA, however, after making a show of going back, returned with two tents, pitched them up and presented us with a fait accompli. It was evident that this was a pre-decided tactic on their part. This would become a recurring feature in the negotiations, in that the PLA would assume that all their proposals had been accepted whereas they had only been 'heard'.

I only got to know of this request the next morning and immediately turned it down but was then told that the tents had already been pitched. I was quite unhappy at this turn of events as was the NSA when I reported the matter to him a little later. I felt that the PLA should be asked to move back forthwith. However, Northern Command felt that the location was not suitable for camping and the tents would in any case get submerged as the water levels in the river would rise in the summer. I wasn't entirely convinced, but since this had been the first HMCL, and the beginning of the disengagement process, this was grudgingly acceded to, especially since the tents had already been pitched. However, it was impressed upon Northern Command that they should keep reminding the PLA about the temporary nature of this arrangement and keep pressing them to withdraw. The Command and Corps insisted that it was not an issue and they could get it vacated at any time.

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